



Audiophile headphones

Audiophilia, at least the way it is practiced, is more of a cult than a science. It's so subjective an experience that over the years esoteric customs have evolved in this subculture such as obsession over specialist cables, burn-in times, vintage amps and hundreds of nebulous ways in which audiophiles try to quantify their experiences into words.

The makers of audiophile gear, in this case headphones, couldn't possibly be complaining. They are only too happy to supply a hungry audience with tweaked and tuned headphone variations to suit every subjectivity-ridden ear. The sweetest outcome is that we get to try out so many different units and models through the year that it's eargasms all year round.

This year saw some genre-defining audio pieces come into the test center. From the house of Sennheiser to Audio-Technica, Logic3, AKG, Harman/Kardon – we had a variety to die for. That being said, recency in the audio realm isn't all that paramount, because a 10-year old design could still kick some "cutting edge" contemporary @\$\$.

Zero1 winner Sennheiser HD 700

From the moment you hold them in your hand you know right away you're going to be privy to something great. The ear cups are open circumaural and the stainless steel grille mesh on the outside is more than just eye candy. It is specifically designed to direct and control the flow of air and reduce harmonic distortion. There's



Harman/Kardon CL

Price: ₹9,990



Sennheiser Momentum

Price: ₹24,900



Audio-Technica ATH AD500X

Price: ₹9,990

virtually no isolation, but sound quality is superlative. The sound signature is almost sparkly and so open, you get a brilliant wide soundstage. Vocal performance does not take a beating even when the instrument density is high. They are fairly neutral, which for most people means bass shy. As for the performance the headphones deliver brilliant dynamic range – you'll hear everything from the quietest clink of a feather touched cymbal, to the loudest scream of a wailing guitar.

Worthy mentions

Harman/Kardon CL

The headphone has a particularly sweet sound signature. You'll especially relish these if you're preference in music is guitar driven rock. By and large supra-aural headphones have a tough time competing with circumaurals in terms of comfort, but these cans are extremely comfortable even over extended listening. Bass is accurate and just the right amount over the standard flat response neutral headphones. Definitely worth the asking price.

Sennheiser Momentum

The higher-end of the spectrum is powerful on the Sennheiser Momentum. Vocals are always given equal attention as the rest of the mix, which is critical for most tracks. In essence, the Sennheiser Momentum is very comfortable with all kinds of music – upbeat, unplugged, or even the slow tracks. Appeal to a wide demographic is pretty difficult for most audio equipment, but the Momentum does seem to have its grip on what is pretty much the perfect balance.

Audio-Technica ATH AD500X

The AD 500X takes off from where the AD300s left off, but manage to take the sound quality several notches higher. If ever you are looking for the definition of a bright sound signature these are the cans. For the price, these are perfect circumaural headphones for home. Period.

AKG K551

For closed back headphones the AKG K551 is surprisingly open and airy. The precision and clarity is through the roof. We get the same precise flat-response signature we loved on the older K271 MKII or K240 MKII we had with us earlier this year. However – and this is a huge listener's bias – they will be construed as bass shy for sure by most people. If you want your 20 to 150 KHz space bumped up these are not the cans for you. As for being portable they do fold flat but the ear cups are huge – if you want precision, however, look no further.



◀ HEADPHONES –
AUDIOPHILE:
SENNHEISER HD 700
Price: ₹59,990